



Through It *& Through It*

A Single Mom's Guide to Surviving Divorce and
Rebuilding After



by Hillary Ackermann

Before We Start



Hey. I'm so sorry you're here. Not here in this guide, but here in this season. I know how heavy it is. I know how much it hurts to have the breath knocked out of you by the very life you were trying so hard to build.

I need you to know something right up front: I'm not a therapist. I'm not a life coach. I don't have a psychology degree, and I don't have it all figured out. I'm a mom who went through the absolute worst thing, thought I wouldn't survive it, and somehow came out the other side. I wrote down everything I wish someone had told me when I was crying on the bathroom floor.

Whether you are currently in the eye of the storm, wandering blindly through the fog of transition, or standing in the rubble trying to figure out how to rebuild, this guide is for you. It's for the days you feel powerful, and it's especially for the days you can't get out of bed.

You are going to feel crazy sometimes. You're going to feel profound grief, absolute rage, and terrifying uncertainty. But you are not crazy. You are not broken beyond repair. You are grieving a life that was supposed to be, while simultaneously having to build a new one. It's an impossible task, but you are going to do it anyway.

Take what you need from these pages. Leave what you don't. Write in the margins, cry on the paper, skip the days you can't face it. Just keep going. You are not alone, and you are going to be okay. Actually, you're going to be better than okay. You'll see.

With love,

Hillary x

How to Use This Guide



There is no right way to do this. Seriously. You can read it front to back like a book, or you can flip to the section that matches where you are right now and start there. Nobody is grading you.

If you're in the middle of the chaos, start with Section 1. If the storm has passed but you feel lost, skip to Section 2. If you're ready to start rebuilding, Section 3 is waiting. If you need God but you're mad at Him, Section 4 won't judge you. And if you just need to write it out, Section 5 is all yours.

You can print this entire guide and write in it with a pen (highly recommended, there's something healing about ink on paper). Or you can keep it on your phone and fill in the journal prompts digitally. Or you can just read it in bed at midnight and skip the writing entirely. Whatever gets you through.

Come back to it. The page that doesn't hit today might wreck you in three months, in the best way. This guide isn't a one-time read. It's a companion for the whole journey.

A Quick Note

This guide is based on personal experience and is meant to encourage, support, and walk alongside you. It is not a substitute for professional therapy, legal counsel, or financial advice. If you are in crisis or experiencing abuse, please reach out to the resources on the last page of this guide immediately. You deserve professional support, and there is no shame in asking for it.

Table of Contents



Section 1: Surviving the Storm	4
————— ◆ —————	
Section 2: Navigating the Fog	12
————— ◆ —————	
Section 3: The Rebuild	20
————— ◆ —————	
Section 4: Faith Through It	28
————— ◆ —————	
Section 5: Letters to Yourself	35
————— ◆ —————	
Bonus: Encouragement Cards & Resources	41



Section 1

Surviving the Storm

*For the days when everything is falling apart and you're
still packing lunches.*



First Things First

When the world is spinning, you don't need a five-year plan. You just need to know what to do in the next five minutes. This list is about protection, preparation, and survival. Do what you can, one box at a time.

- ☐ Find a lawyer or call your local legal aid (you don't have to figure this out alone).
- ☐ Open a bank account in just your name.
- ☐ Gather important documents (birth certificates, marriage license, tax returns, insurance info, bank statements).
- ☐ Tell ONE person you trust — you need a witness to your reality.
- ☐ Write down your support system: 3 people you can call at 2am.
- ☐ Change passwords (email, bank, social media).
- ☐ Take photos of important documents and store them somewhere safe.
- ☐ Breathe. Then breathe again. You're doing it.

You don't have to do it all today. Just do the next right thing.

How to Tell the Kids



This is the conversation you've been dreading. There is no perfect script, but there are principles that will protect their hearts as much as possible while their world shifts.

1. **Keep it simple.** They don't need adult details.
2. **Tell them together if you can.** If you can't, that's okay too.
3. **Don't blame.** Even when you want to. Especially when you want to.
4. **Let them feel whatever they feel** — anger, sadness, confusion, even nothing at all.
5. **Reassure them OVER and OVER** that this is not their fault.
6. **Let them ask the same question 100 times.** They're processing.
7. **Keep their routine as normal** as humanly possible.
8. **Tell them they are loved by both parents.** Even if you have to grit your teeth.

◆ Hillary, add your story here:

This is where your personal story goes. The day you told your kids. What you felt, what you said, what happened after. Your readers need to hear how imperfect and real it was. Write it in your own words and it will be the most powerful page in this entire guide.

The Survival Week Planner

For when you can only see one day at a time.

Monday

One thing I have to do: _____

One thing for the kids: _____

One thing for me: _____

Who I can call if I lose it: _____

Tuesday

One thing I have to do: _____

One thing for the kids: _____

One thing for me: _____

Who I can call if I lose it: _____

Wednesday

One thing I have to do: _____

One thing for the kids: _____

One thing for me: _____

Who I can call if I lose it: _____

Thursday

One thing I have to do: _____

One thing for the kids: _____

One thing for me: _____

Who I can call if I lose it: _____

Friday

One thing I have to do: _____

One thing for the kids: _____

One thing for me: _____

Who I can call if I lose it: _____

Saturday

To do: _____

For me: _____

Sunday

To do: _____

For me: _____

Things You're Allowed to Feel

Whatever you're feeling, it's allowed. There's no wrong way to grieve a life that was supposed to be.

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Angry. | ☐ Hopeless. |
| ☐ Relieved. | ☐ Lonely. |
| ☐ Guilty for feeling relieved. | ☐ Strong. |
| ☐ Scared. | ☐ Weak. |
| ☐ Numb. | ☐ Like you're failing. |
| ☐ Sad. | ☐ Like you're finally winning. |
| ☐ Free. | ☐ Exhausted. |
| ☐ Confused. | ☐ Wide awake at 3am. |
| ☐ Furious. | ☐ Like crying in the Target parking lot. |
| ☐ Heartbroken. | ☐ Like laughing at something stupid. |
| ☐ Embarrassed. | ☐ All of the above at the same time. |
| ☐ Hopeful. | ☐ None of the above. |

An Honest Prayer for the Storm



God, I don't even know what to ask for right now.

I just need you to show up, because I absolutely cannot do this alone.

The waves are too high, the night is too dark, and I am so entirely exhausted.

I'm angry. I'm tired. I'm scared of who I'm becoming and terrified of who I'm not anymore. Half the time I can't catch my breath, and the other half I'm just bracing for the next hit. Please hold my kids' hearts, because my hands are shaking too much to do it perfectly. Please protect their minds from the chaos of adults.

If you are close to the brokenhearted, please sit right next to me. I don't need you to fix it all today, but I do need you to give me enough strength to pack the lunches, sign the papers, and survive until bedtime. Give me grace for my massive mistakes, and let me feel Your presence when the house is too quiet.

Hold me together while I fall apart.

Amen. (I think.)

The hardest part of today was...

One thing I need someone to know but can't say out loud is...

Right now, I'm surviving by...



"You are surviving something most people couldn't. Don't forget that."





Section 2

Navigating the Fog

*For the days when the chaos stops but the confusion
doesn't.*



The Identity Crisis Nobody Warned You About



You spend years building a life around another person. You learn their coffee order, their moods, their family dynamics. You compromise on the paint colors, the holiday schedules, the city you live in. You intertwine your roots so deeply that you forget where you end and they begin.

And then, one day, the blueprint is just gone. Burned up. Erased. And nobody prepares you for the terrifying quiet that follows. The silence where their opinions, their presence, and their expectations used to be.

Suddenly you are standing in the grocery store aisle realizing you don't even know what kind of bread *you* like, because you've been buying his favorite for ten years. You look in the mirror and think, "Who is this woman?" You aren't a wife anymore. If the kids are gone half the time, sometimes you feel like you aren't even a full-time mom anymore. It is completely disorienting.

Listen to me: this feeling of being entirely unmoored is normal. It feels like a breakdown, but I promise you, it's a reconstruction. You have been stripped down to the studs. The house you built fell down, yes. But the foundation is still there. And the best part about being stripped down to the studs is that now, you get to decide what the house looks like.

You aren't lost. You are just meeting yourself again for the first time in a long time. Be gentle with her. She's been through a lot.

Things That Are Yours Now

List 10 things that are YOURS now. Not his. Not the family's. Yours.

Examples: Your taste in music. Your parenting style. Your faith. Your Thursday nights. Your future.

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

5. _____

6. _____

7. _____

8. _____

9. _____

10. _____

The Grief Nobody Understands



When someone dies, people bring casseroles. They send cards. Society has a script for death. But when a marriage dies, especially when the person is still walking around in the world, nobody knows what to do. So they often do nothing, and you are left to grieve in a vacuum.

You aren't just grieving a person. You're grieving the loss of a future you had already mapped out in your head. You're grieving the fact that the family photos on your phone suddenly feel like a lie. You're grieving the inside jokes that now have nowhere to land, and the empty chair at the dinner table.

You grieve the holidays that will never look the same. The traditions you have to abandon or agonizingly modify. The time you will now have to spend away from your own children. That is a very specific, sharp kind of pain that only someone who has shared custody can understand.

I need you to know that this grief is valid. It is real. It is okay if you are mourning a man who treated you terribly, because you are mourning the dream of who he was supposed to be. It is okay if you are the one who left, and you are still devastated. Your heart is allowed to be broken, no matter how the shattering happened.

Fog Season Self-Care

Not bubble baths. The basics.

- ☐ Did you eat today? An actual meal, not just kids' leftover crusts.
- ☐ Did you drink water? Not coffee. Water.
- ☐ Did you talk to someone who isn't five years old?
- ☐ Did you go outside for ten minutes?
- ☐ Did you cry and not apologize for it?
- ☐ Did you say no to something that drained you?
- ☐ Did you put on real clothes? (Optional. Some days a hoodie counts.)
- ☐ Did you stretch, walk, or move your body in any way?
- ☐ Did you sleep more than four hours?
- ☐ Did you forgive yourself for the days you couldn't do any of this?

Survival is self-care right now. Keep it beautifully basic.

An Honest Prayer for the Fog



Lord, the dust has settled, but I still can't see the road ahead.

Everything feels thick and confusing. I am trying to make decisions for a future I didn't plan for, and I feel so entirely unqualified for my own life right now. I don't know who I am without this marriage, and I am scared that my best days are behind me.

Please give me clarity when my mind is spinning. Give me patience with my own healing, because I want to rush to the part where I'm okay, but I know I'm not there yet. Give me the strength to just keep walking, even when I can't see past my own two feet.

Remind me that You are leading me, even in the fog. Remind me that the sun is still there, even when the clouds are thick.

Amen.

Before my marriage, I used to love...

Something I'm starting to realize about myself is...

The version of me I want to become looks like...

A Letter to the Woman in the Fog



Hey you.

I know what it feels like to wake up and stare at the ceiling, wondering how this became your life. I know the heavy, wet blanket of confusion that sits on your chest while you make breakfast. The paperwork is filed, the boxes are unpacked, but your brain is still lagging behind, desperately trying to compute a reality it refuses to accept.

I need to tell you something very important: You are not lost. You are just in between. You are in the terrifying, sacred space between who you were and who you are becoming.

It feels like wandering. It feels like you've been dropped in the middle of a foreign country where you don't speak the language and the map is written in invisible ink. But you aren't lost. You are doing the quiet, unseen, exhausting work of recalibration. Every time you make a choice that aligns with your peace, you are drawing a new map.

I know it doesn't feel like it right now, but the fog lifts. I promise you it lifts. One day, you'll be driving in your car, listening to a song, and you'll realize you haven't cried in a week. One day, the air will feel crisp again. You will see the horizon.

Until then, just take the next step. You don't need to see the whole staircase. Just the step right in front of you.

I love you. I'm rooting for you.

— H



Section 3

The Rebuild

*For the day you wake up and make a decision that's just for
you.*



Your New Non-Negotiables

You get to set the rules for your life now. Write them down in ink.

5 Things I Will Never Tolerate Again

- _____
1. _____
- _____
2. _____
- _____
3. _____
- _____
4. _____
- _____
5. _____

5 Things I Refuse to Live Without

- _____
1. _____
- _____
2. _____
- _____
3. _____
- _____
4. _____
- _____
5. _____

Building a Routine That's Actually Yours

Use this space to block out a week that serves your family and protects your peace.

Morning Blocks (The Anchors)

Afternoon / Kids' Schedules

Evening Blocks (The Wind Down)

One thing JUST for me every day:

Co-Parenting Without Losing Your Mind

Co-parenting with an ex is a masterclass in emotional regulation. Here is your cheat sheet for keeping your sanity intact.

1. **Keep communication about the kids ONLY.** No essays. No emotional bait. Business only.
2. **Use a co-parenting app** if you need a buffer (OurFamilyWizard, TalkingParents). It creates accountability.
3. **Don't badmouth him in front of the kids.** Even when he entirely deserves it. Vent to your friends, your therapist, your diary.
4. **Pick your battles.** Is this hill worth dying on, or is it just a Tuesday? Protect your peace above being right.
5. **You don't have to be friends.** You just have to be functional. Friendly distance is a beautiful boundary.
6. **Don't respond when you're activated.** Draft it, delete it. Wait 24 hours. If it's still urgent, wait another 24.
7. **Document everything in writing.** Texts, emails, screenshots. Just in case you ever need it.
8. **Their relationship with their dad is not your job to manage.** You are only responsible for your house, your rules, and your relationship with them.

Single Mom Finances 101

This isn't overwhelming. It's a starting point. Knowledge is power.

Monthly income: \$ _____

Fixed expenses (rent, utilities, car, insurance): \$ _____

Kid expenses (childcare, school, activities): \$ _____

Groceries & household: \$ _____

Debt payments: \$ _____

Savings goal: \$ _____

One "just for me" line item: \$ _____

Buffer for the unexpected: \$ _____

An Honest Prayer for the Rebuild



Thank you for getting me here.

I honestly didn't think I would make it through those first few months. I thought the grief would drown me, but here I am. Breathing. Standing. Building.

Lord, give me the courage to keep building. When I feel weary, when the single-parent exhaustion hits me like a brick wall, remind me of how far I've come. Remind me that I am capable of hard things.

Help me build a home that is filled with peace, even if it's smaller, even if it's different. Let my kids feel the calm in our house. Help me make wise choices with my money, my time, and my heart.

Help me build something beautiful with what's left. I trust that the story isn't over, and I ask you to bless this new chapter more than I could ever imagine.

Amen.

One decision I made this week that was just for me...

I'm proud of myself for...

Six months from now, I want my life to look like...



*"You are not starting over. You are
starting from experience."*





Section 4

Faith Through It

*For the conversations with God that don't sound like
Sunday school.*



When You're Mad at God (And That's Okay)

In Christian circles, there is often a tremendous pressure to put a shiny bow on our suffering. To quote a scripture, smile through the tears, and say, "God is good all the time." And while God is good, your situation right now might be terrible.

If you are angry at God right now, I need you to hear this: He can handle it. He is not offended by your humanity. He is not shocked by your rage, your confusion, or your deeply painful "Why me?" questions.

You do not have to perform a peace you don't feel. You do not have to pretend to be a spiritual giant while your life is falling apart. The Psalms are filled with people screaming at the sky, asking God why He abandoned them, why the wicked prosper, and why it hurts so much. If David was allowed to be brutally honest, so are you.

Anger is often just the bodyguard for deep sadness. When you yell at God in your car, you are actually just showing Him your broken heart. Keep talking to Him, even if it sounds angry. The opposite of faith isn't anger; it's apathy. The fact that you are wrestling with Him means you are still holding on.

Let it be messy. He's not going anywhere.

10 Scriptures for the Hardest Days



Psalm 34:18 — *"The Lord is close to the brokenhearted and saves those who are crushed in spirit."*

This one got me through the nights when I couldn't sleep. He is right here in the mess. Not waiting on the other side of it.

Jeremiah 29:11 — *"For I know the plans I have for you, plans to prosper you and not to harm you."*

Some days I had to read this through gritted teeth. But it's still true even when it doesn't feel true yet.

Isaiah 41:10 — *"Do not fear, for I am with you... I will strengthen you and help you."*

When the panic came at 2am, I would whisper this to myself in the dark like a heartbeat.

Psalm 147:3 — *"He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds."*

He is not annoyed by your tears. He is gathering them up and stitching you back together.

Romans 8:28 — *"And we know that in all things God works for the good of those who love him."*

ALL things. Even this. Even the parts you wouldn't wish on your worst enemy.

Proverbs 3:5-6 — *"Trust in the Lord with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding."*

I've stopped trying to understand. I'm just trying to trust. That has to be enough for today.

Psalm 46:5 — *"God is within her, she will not fall; God will help her at break of day."*

Tape this to your bathroom mirror. Read it when you brush your teeth. She will not fall. That's you.

2 Corinthians 12:9 — *"My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness."*

You don't have to have it together. Your falling-apart is exactly where He does His best work.

Psalm 23:4 — *"Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil."*

You are walking THROUGH. Not staying. Keep moving. He is with you.

Lamentations 3:22-23 — *"His mercies are new every morning; great is your faithfulness."*

Yesterday's mess does not get to follow you into today. New mercies. Every single morning.

Emergency Prayers

Short. Real. For the moments when you don't have many words left.

When You're Angry

God, I am furious. At him. At this situation. Maybe even at You. I'm bringing it all to You instead of burying it. Help me feel it without letting it become me. Amen.

When You're Lonely

Lord, the silence is so loud tonight. Please sit with me. Remind me that I am not actually alone, even when the bed feels too big and the house feels too quiet. Be near. Amen.

When the Kids Are Struggling

Father, You love them more than I do, and I didn't think that was possible. Cover them. Comfort them where I can't. Use even this for their good. Amen.

When You See Him With Someone New

God, that hurt more than I expected. Catch the parts of me that just shattered. Don't let bitterness take root. Remind me my future has nothing to do with his. Amen.

When You Doubt Yourself

Lord, the lies are loud today. Drown them out with Your truth. Remind me who You say I am: chosen, capable, loved, enough. Amen.

When You Feel Hopeful and Guilty About It

God, I felt joy today and immediately felt bad about it. Help me let myself be happy again. Joy is not betrayal. Joy is healing. Thank You for the lift. Amen.

A Letter to God



Dear God, here's everything I haven't said out loud yet...

A moment I felt God show up this week...

Something I'm struggling to trust Him with...

A prayer I'm too scared to pray out loud is...



*"He is close to the brokenhearted.
Especially yours."*





Section 5

Letters to Yourself

*For the woman you were, the woman you are, and the
woman you're becoming.*



A Letter to the Woman I Was Before the Divorce



Dear _____,

Before everything changed, you were...

Love, Me

A Letter to the Woman in the Middle of It



Dear _____,

I know you can't see it right now, but...

Love, Me

A Letter to the Woman I'm Becoming



Dear future me,

By the time you read this, I hope...

With hope, Me

Promises I'm Making to Myself



These are mine. Not anyone else's. Mine.

1.

2.

3.

4.

5.

6.

7.

8.

9.

10.



You Made It Through This Guide. And You'll Make It Through This Season.



If you read these pages and cried, good. If you wrote in the margins, even better. If you skipped half of it because it was too much, that's okay too. This guide will be here when you're ready.

Hear me when I tell you this: *you are not alone*. There is an entire sisterhood of women who have walked this exact road, and we are cheering for you from the other side. You are stronger than you think, braver than you feel, and loved beyond what you can see right now.

The best chapters of your life are not behind you. They are being written in this very moment, with shaky hands and a steadier soul.

Now go show your kids what it looks like when mom chooses herself.

— Hillary x





Bonus

Encouragement Cards

*Screenshot these. Save them to your phone. Read them on
the hard days.*



Save These to Your Phone

Screenshot each card. Set one as your wallpaper. Change it when you need to.

"You are not what happened to you. You are what you choose to become."

@hillackermann

"She didn't just survive it. She rebuilt from it."

@hillackermann

"God is within her. She will not fall."

— Psalm 46:5

@hillackermann

I Made It Through Today

Cut these out or screenshot them. One for every day you need a reminder.

I am allowed to grieve and grow at the same time.

My kids don't need a perfect mom. They need a healing one.

I did not fail. I chose peace.

The fog lifts. I promise it lifts.

I am being rebuilt, not destroyed.

Today I survived. That is enough.

Resources That Actually Help

— ♦ —

You don't have to do this alone. Here are real, vetted resources for when you need more than a journal prompt.

Crisis Support

National Domestic Violence Hotline: 1-800-799-7233

Crisis Text Line: Text HOME to 741741

National Suicide Prevention Lifeline: 988

Legal Help

LegalAid.org — free legal assistance by state

WomensLaw.org — legal information for women experiencing abuse

Co-Parenting Tools

OurFamilyWizard — co-parenting communication app

TalkingParents — documented co-parent messaging

Therapy & Counseling

BetterHelp.com — affordable online therapy

OpenPath.com — low-cost therapy (\$30-\$80/session)

FaithfulCounseling.com — faith-based online counseling

Financial Help

SingleMomIncome.com — financial tips and side income ideas

211.org — local assistance for rent, utilities, food, childcare

Books Worth Reading

Boundaries by Henry Cloud & John Townsend

It's OK That You're Not OK by Megan Devine

Get Out of Your Head by Jennie Allen

